President) and Henry (Hank) Paulson, US Treasury Secretary in Beijing in 2008. Wang tells Paulson: ‘You were my teacher. But now I am in my teacher’s domain and look at your system, Hank. We aren’t sure we should be learning from you anymore.’ [3]

The US would no longer serve as a model for China to emulate. China emerged from the global financial and economic crisis in much better shape than the US and Europe, with its GDP growth back to 6–7 per cent per annum, registered before the crisis. This significantly reduced the economic asymmetry between them. China began to look at its own brand of economic management, with strict state regulation, as much more efficient than the now discredited Washington Consensus promoted by the US, which advocated all-round deregulation, lifting of controls and letting the market be its own regulator.

~

China’s enhanced profile in the global economy began to be reflected in a more assertive foreign policy, but this manifested more gradually. During the early years of the twenty-first century, China was ready to identify itself as an emerging economy in the same league as Brazil, India, Mexico and South Africa. It took part in the G-8 plus G-5 summits first convened in Gleneagles in the UK in 2005, and in subsequent such summits. At the climate change negotiations, it worked together with Brazil, India and South Africa in the BASIC group and was happy to be included as one of the BRICS countries – Brazil, Russia, India, China and South Africa – once this group of emerging countries was identified as potential major economic powers in the new millennium. However, post the global financial and economic crisis of 2007–2008, China has begun to increasingly benchmark itself with the US, describing its relations with the US as a ‘new type of great power relations’. Thus, in 2015, it was a bilateral understanding reached between US President Obama and Chinese President Xi Jinping on the eve of the Paris Climate Change Summit which became the template for the Paris Climate Change Agreement. China did not feel the need to consult its partners in the BASIC group any longer. And yet, in 2009, at the